

Thirdly, Jerome mistranslates and misunderstands.

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Fourthly, Jerome dishonestly conceals both his ignorance and his debt to Eusebius.

Well, well, well, it appears that one should read Jerome with a full salt shaker to hand. Perhaps my closing sentence above should have been: Not being stupid, he didn't! However, I continue to insist that Jerome could not have been so grossly stupid and/or dishonest as to make the ridiculous statement attributed to him. Down with **forgery**!¹

Defining 'Preservation'

We understand that the human authors of Scripture wrote under inspiration, by which we mean that the Holy Spirit superintended the process with the result that they wrote just what He wanted them to write (respecting the norms that rule the use of language). The authors were inspired, protected from error, but not the copyists down through the years. There is nothing like actually collating a number of MSS to give one an appreciation for the divine preservation of the Text, a process more complicated than inspiration. (Satan was not allowed to interfere in the inspiring, but was in the preserving.)

The purpose of this note is to 'chew' a bit on the question of just how to evaluate a copy's representation of its archetypal form, and hence its preservation thereof. I consider that the following should not be regarded as 'variants', or deviations from the archetype:

1. Whether a number is written out or given with the letters;
2. Whether a letter (*alpha*) is written out or given with the letter;
3. Abbreviations or 'shorthand' forms (these are especially frequent at the end of a line), where the identity of the word and its meaning are not touched; the so-called 'nomina sacra' are probably the best known examples.

Both parchment and ink were prepared by hand, and were hard to come by, so any legitimate means of economizing those materials would be viewed as entirely appropriate. This attitude is reflected in the first three items.

¹ For detailed documentation and an exhaustive discussion of other aspects of this question, see Burgon, *The Last Twelve Verses according to S. Mark*, pp. 19-31, 38-69, 265-90.